

FOSS Spells Economic Success for Knimbus

Gurgaon-based Knimbus, a one-of-its-kind niche online community for researchers across the globe, has successfully used FOSS to generate a positive cash flow, catapult its business up the ladder, and earn a great reputation across the world.



Rahul Agarwalla (L) and Tarun Arora (R), co-founders of Knimbus at their office in Gurgaon

While enterprises are still apprehensive about FOSS as a robust business model, firms like Knimbus have figured out how to use open source technology to beef up their business and reach out to thousands of researchers through their networking platform. Built like a social networking site, Knimbus was launched by two entrepreneurs, Rahul Agarwalla and Tarun Arora, in September 2011. It enables scientists to access interesting content, collaborate, share innovative discoveries and connect with peers. Since its inception, the user base of Knimbus has grown exponentially to over 100,000 scientists and researchers. Not many know that the firm has received support from foreign investors of Indian origin to the extent of Rs 30 million. Backed by

a development team that comprises 8-10 professionals with expertise in open source technologies, Knimbus has made a mark in this niche networking domain.

A sense of contentment was evident in CEO and co-founder Rahul Agarwalla when we caught up with him for a candid chat. Explaining why he chose to adopt the FOSS model for his business, he quipped, "Our choice of technology was based on basic considerations like reliability, security, transparency, fast-paced development and cost. Open source solutions are community developed and peer reviewed, which leads to more reliability. The Internet ecosystem is largely composed of open source programs such as DNS, Sendmail and Apache, and languages such as HTML, Perl etc. Open source enables the community to examine